

Exploration of Blackmail Scam and Creation of Scammer’s Codebook

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Abstract

Blackmail scamming is one of the most personal and emotionally driven forms of online fraud. Unlike typical scams that only focus on stealing money, blackmail scams target people’s fears, secrets, vulnerabilities, and emotions to force them into doing what the scammer wants. As such, victims often remain undisclosed due to the trauma, fear of exposure, and other factors making it one of the lesser-known scam categories compared to other forms of attack such as crypto scams, technical support scams, and others. This project explores how blackmail scammers use psychological pressure, emotional manipulation, and fear-based tactics to gain control over their victims. By analyzing real-world examples and communication patterns through victim’s publicly available datasource – the research aims to identify common warning signs and behaviors that can help people recognize these scams before they fall victim. More specifically, research contribute to the creation of a “Scammer Code Book” — a tool designed to (i) educate users on how to avoid the pitfalls of blackmail scams; (ii) create a platform-based recommendation demonstrating how scammers abuse social media and other online links to bait potential victims; and (iii) provide recommendations for authorities and policymakers based on our findings. Through understanding how these scams work through their end-to-end cycle analysis, we hope to make online spaces safer and help individuals feel more confident when facing potential threats.

1 Introduction

Blackmail scamming represents a complex and psychologically intrusive subset of cyber crime in which offenders exploit victims’ fears, secrets, and emotional vulnerabilities for financial, social, or psychological gain. Unlike other forms of digital fraud, such as investment scams, technical support schemes, or cryptocurrency theft, blackmail scams directly target the individual’s identity, reputation, or relationships. These attacks often involve coercive threats, extortion, and

strategic manipulation of shame, guilt, and fear. Because victims often experience intense emotional distress, many choose not to disclose the incident, making blackmail scamming an under-reported domain within online fraud research and law-enforcement statistics.

Blackmail scamming can be broadly defined as the act of threatening an individual with the disclosure of harmful, embarrassing, or private information unless the victim complies with the scammer’s demands. These demands typically involve money, but many also include further communication, the sharing of additional personal data, or ongoing compliance within a psychological coercion cycle.

Public data suggests that blackmail and extortion-based cyber crimes are increasing in scope and sophistication. According to the Federal Trade Commission (FTC), reports of extortion scams have surged dramatically over the past several years, with U.s. consumers losing over 1.1 billion dollars to impersonation and extortion scams in 2023 alone, representing one of the largest categories of reported fraud losses nationally. [6] Similarly, the FBI’s Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) recorded more than 51,000 extortion-related complaints in 2023, noting that extortion remains one of the most frequently reported cyber crime types. [5] However, because blackmail victims often experience shame, fear of exposure, or reputation concerns, the true number of affected individual is believed to be significantly higher. Publicly available online reports also show considerable engagement with blackmail-related complaints on crowd-sourced platforms. For example, Chainabuse, a public reporting site for crypto-sourced scams, hosts thousands of blackmail and sextortion reports submitted by victims, illustrating both the scale and visibility of this problem in everyday digital environments. [3]

Despite the prevalence and severity of blackmail scams, the mechanisms through which scammers operate remain insufficiently documented in academic literature. Blackmail scammers weaponize psychological pressure, exploit emotional vulnerabilities, and often follow distinct communication patterns that differ from more transactional forms of cyber fraud. Understanding this behavioral dimension is essential

for building effective user-education tools, platform-level interventions, and law-enforcement responses. The goal of this research is therefore to systematically analyze real world blackmail scam communications to understand how scammers attempt to influence, manipulate, and coerce victims. By transforming fragmented reports into structured data, this work seeks to strengthen public awareness, inform preventative strategies, and contribute to the cybersecurity community.

This study provides three key contributions. (1) It compiles and analyzes a large collection public blackmail scam reports and ransomware ransom notes to identify communication features, threat patterns, and emotional manipulation tactics. (2) It proposes an extensible "Scammer Code Book" framework designed to categorize scammer behavior and assist users, platforms, and policymakers in recognizing and responding to these threats. (3) It introduces a systematic workflow for combining data scraping, qualitative coding, and behavioral analysis to study emotionally driven cyber crimes. Drawing from these contributions, the study addresses the following research questions:

1. Why do blackmail scammers scam people? What motivates them, and what psychological or economic drives influence their behavior?
2. How do blackmail scammers conduct their attacks? What communication strategies, threat patterns, or persuasive tactics are the most commonly used?
3. Who is the ideal target or audience? What characteristics, behaviors, or vulnerabilities of the victim are the most frequently exploited?

Through this examination, the research aims to shed light on one of the most personal and emotionally consequential forms of online fraud and provide a foundational framework for future cyber crime behavior analysis.

2 System Design

The system for this research is designed to collect, filter, analyze, and categorize extortion-based communications from blackmail scamming as you see in *Figure 1*. The purpose of this design is to create a structured framework that transforms raw, unorganized victim-reported messages and ransom notes into a standardized dataset suitable for psychological and linguistic analysis. Through a combination of web scraping, manual verification, text preprocessing, and qualitative coding, the system ensure that both types of extortion messages can be compared on equal analytical terms. This structured pipeline ultimately supports the creation of a comprehensive *Scammer Code Book*, a tool that show a scammer's perspective through common manipulative strategies used across different forms of online coercion.



Figure 1: System Design Workflow

2.1 Data Collection

The data collection phase incorporates two primary streams of extortion communication: individual blackmail messages submitted by victims and official ransom notes published by ransomware groups. Blackmail scam messages were sourced online communities, cyber-awareness platforms, ChainAbuse reports, Reddit threads, and other OSINT-based forums where victims publicly share scam emails or messages. These submissions typically include the scammer's full text, making them valuable for observing emotional manipulation techniques. Each entry was reviewed to ensure that only genuine blackmail attempts, those using threats of exposure, personal secrets, or fear, were included.

Ransomware data was collected from the public repository "ransomware.live", which aggregates ransom notes from dozens of known ransomware groups. A custom scraping tool retrieved structured attributes such as the ransomware group name, the ransom note file name, and a link to the text file. By creating a program that parses the "<code id='Content'>" element embedded in each webpage, the system extracted the complete text of each extortion note. This method ensures high-quality, direct-source data representing the "official" communications ransomware operators deliver to victims. Collectively, the two data sources provide a diverse yet complementary dataset of extortion practices.

2.2 Data Filtration

After collection, all data underwent a standardized filtration process to ensure the messages were clean, consistent, and suitable for direct comparison. Any entries containing commentary, duplicate threads, incomplete transcripts, or content irrelevant to extortion were removed. The remaining data was cleaned using a preprocessing pipeline that included lowercasing, stripping HTML markup, removing encoding artifacts, and eliminating boilerplate text such as email headers or metadata.

To support more meaningful analysis, each message was segmented into conceptual components, such as initial hook statements, threat declarations, payment instructions, and consequences for noncompliance. Blackmail messages, which vary greatly in tone and structure, were manually reviewed to preserve emotional nuance. Ransomware notes, which follow more consistent formatting, were cleaned to isolate the extortion message from technical instructions or system details. This preprocessing stage created a uniform format that supports both linguistic analysis and thematic comparison.

2.3 Data Analysis

The analysis phase integrates qualitative and computational methods to explore the psychological mechanisms present in extortion messaging. For blackmail scams, the emphasis was placed on emotional tone, intimidation strategies, urgency cues, and manipulative framing, especially techniques that exploit fear, shame, or secrecy. In contrast, ransomware notes were analyzed for operational coercion, such as data-leak threats, countdown timers, justification narratives, assurances of "professionalism", and claims of successful decryption.

Linguistic patterns were identified across both data types, including repeated use of conditional threats, time pressure, escalations, emotional hooks, and payoff instructions. While blackmail scams tend to rely on personal manipulation, ransomware messages often attempt to project authority, inevitability, and control. These insights were coded into structured themes, allowing the two datasets, despite their differences, to be examined through a shared analytical lens.

2.4 Code-book Creation

The final stage of the system framework is the development of the Scammer Code Book, a structured taxonomy of manipulation tactics, linguistic patterns, behavioral indicators, and psychological pressure mechanisms used across both blackmail scams and ransomware extortion. The goal of the Code Book is to transform unstructured messages into a consistent set of identifiable "scammer strategies" that capture how extortionists create fear, enforce compliance, and maintain control throughout the communication cycle.

To construct the Code Book, themes emerging from the analysis phase were systematically categorized through an iterative coding process. First, recurring patterns in threat language, emotional framing, time pressure, and payment instructions were identified across all messages. Blackmail scams contributed patterns related to personalization and emotional targeting, such as threats of reputation damage, claims of intimate knowledge, or appeals to secrecy. Ransomware notes contributed operational coercion strategies, including threats to publish stolen data, countdown timers, promises of decryption, and assertions of professional legitimacy ("We are not criminals; this is just business"). These elements were compared across datasets to determine which themes were unique to each scam type and which formed universal extortion strategies.

Each tactic will be formalized into a Code Book entry containing:

1. a clear definition of the tactic,
2. example phrases or linguistic markers drawn directly from the dataset,
3. the psychological mechanism involved (e.g., fear, shame, urgency, loss aversion, perceived authority),

4. a brief explanation of why this technique is effective from the scammer's perspective

Where appropriate, the Code Book also includes cross-references showing how the same tactic appears in different forms depending on the scam category. For instance, fear escalation in blackmail may focus on exposure of secrets, while in ransomware it may revolve around irreversible data deletion or public leaks. Similarly, legitimization tactics differ: blackmailers often fabricate stories to appear as spies or hackers, whereas ransomware groups try to appear as organized, reputable entities capable of restoring systems.

Beyond its academic significance, the Code Book is designed as a practical resource. Users, including online platform moderators, awareness educators, cybersecurity analysts, and everyday individuals, can use it to quickly recognize early warning signs of extortion attempts. The structured nature of the Code Book also makes it compatible with automated detection systems: linguistic markers and coded patterns can inform rule-based or machine learning models that flag manipulative or threatening communications in real time. Furthermore, insights from the Code Book can guide policymakers by highlighting manipulative patterns that are not purely technical, demonstrating the need for psychologically-aware approaches in cyber crime response strategies.

By grounding each entry in real-world evidence from both blackmail and ransomware cases, the Code Book captures the full behavioral ecosystem of modern extortion. It not only documents what scammers say but why they say it, how their messaging evolves, and how victims can recognize and resist these tactics. This makes the Code Book the central unifying output of the system design: bridging data, analysis, and real-world application.

3 Results

This section presents the key findings derived from the collected datasets, including victim-reported blackmail cases, ransomware extortion notes, and public community discussions. The goal of the results is not only to highlight the recurring behavioral patterns used by scammers, but also to demonstrate how the combined analysis led to the formation of a unified extortion-focused code book.

Across all data sources, the system collected a diverse set of extortion communications that reveal both the emotional and operational dimensions of blackmail and ransomware. From blackmail-focused datasets (ChainAbuse and Reddit), the majority of victim reports involved email and social media-based sextortion, reputation threats, or impersonation of law-enforcement/hackers. These reports frequently included detailed narratives from victims describing the emotional manipulation involved. The ransomware dataset, sourced from ransomware.live, provided more structured content in the form of ransom notes posted by extortion groups. Each note typ-

ically contained instructions for payment, threats involving data leaks, and claims of professional capability. The ransomware notes exhibited a far more standardized format than blackmail messages, reinforcing the industrialized nature of modern extortion groups.

The qualitative analysis revealed several strong, recurring themes across blackmail scam messages:

- Fear-based pressure - Nearly all messages relied on fear of exposure as the primary lever of control. Scammers regularly threatened to release private information, fabricated secrets, or AI-generated images to coerce victims quickly.
- Personalization tactics - Victims frequently reported that scammers used real names, leaked emails, breached passwords, or social media references to make the threat appear credible.
- Urgency and countdowns - Blackmailers commonly imposed arbitrary deadlines ("You have 24 hours...") to limit a victim's ability to see advice or verify the claims.
- Credibility-building through false authority - Scammers often impersonated hackers, law enforcement, or cybersecurity experts to intimidate victims.

These themes aligned closely with prior literature that describes emotional fraud as relying on anxiety, shame, and panic to reduce rational decision-making.

While ransomware communication lacked the emotional intimacy of blackmail scams, it shared many structural similarities:

- Operational coercion - Threats primarily revolved around business-critical consequences, such as encrypted systems, stolen data, or public leaks.
- Brand identity and professionalization - Many extortion groups presented themselves as "organizations" with logos, dedicated lead sites, help desks, and customer support-style messaging.
- Negotiation framing - Numerous notes portrayed payment as a "business transaction" rather than a crime, attempting to normalize the coercive relationship.
- Proof-of-competence messages - Ransomware groups often claimed they could decrypt files, provided guarantees, or referenced successful past negotiations to increase compliance.

The contrast between emotional blackmail and operational ransomware shows two ends of the extortion spectrum, one exploiting personal vulnerability, the other targeting institutional dependency on data.

Combining both datasets allowed identification of shared extortion tactics that appear consistently across scam types:

- Threat escalation (severity increases if the victim hesitates)
- Legitimization tactics ("We are professionals", "I have evidence", "I know your secret")
- Consequential framing (reputation loss vs. business failure)
- Structured payment instructions
- Isolation tactics ("Do not contact anyone", "Do not try to report this")

These themes became core categories in the Scammer Code Book, allowing the behaviors of scammers to be described in a unified, cross scam taxonomy.

Data saturation was assessed across all three datasets by tracking the cumulative number of unique thematic keyword identified as additional records were processed. The saturation curves for the Ransomware.live notes, ChainAbuse reports, and Reddit blackmail dataset are shown in *Figure 2*. These curves illustrate how quickly each dataset introduced new linguistic or behavioral themes before leveling off.

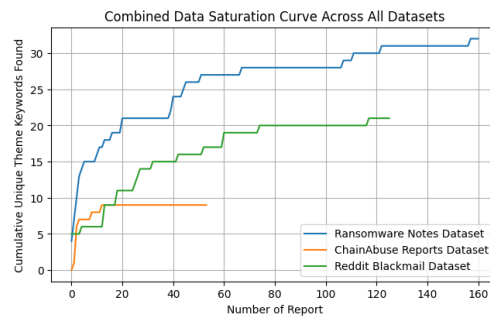


Figure 2: Data saturation curves across all datasets.

Across all datasets, saturation was eventually reached, but the rate and depth varied significantly:

- Ransomware Notes Dataset: This dataset produced the highest overall number of unique themes and showed a gradual climb throughout the entire corpus. New keywords continued appearing even after reading more than 120 notes, though the rate slowed considerably after the first 40-50 records. This slow tapering indicates but still vary in terminology, threat framing, and negotiation language across campaigns. This extended curve suggests a larger thematic space, driven by operational complexity and the diversity of ransomware groups.
- ChainAbuse Reports Dataset: ChainAbuse reports reach saturation quickly. Nearly all unique themes appeared within the first 10-15 submissions, after which the curve flattened almost completely. This reflects the highly

repetitive and formulaic nature of blackmail scam complaints; victims commonly describe the same small set of elements (e.g., threats of exposure, demands for cryptocurrency, urgency, intimidation). Because reports often use similar wording across victims, the dataset stabilized early, confirming that only a modest number of records are needed to capture the dominant patterns.

- **Reddit Blackmail Dataset:** The Reddit dataset produced a moderate number of new themes and plateaued between 80 and 120 posts. Unlike ChainAbuse reports, Reddit submissions include longer narratives, multiple message exchanges, and more contextual detail. This leads to a slower but steady discovery of additional terms related to emotional responses, scammer tactics, and negotiation attempts. Despite the richer descriptions, saturation was still achieved before the dataset's midpoint, confirming thematic consistency across user experiences.

Across all sources, the analysis revealed that:

- Scammers, both individual blackmailers and organized ransomware groups, rely on predictable and repeated psychological and operational strategies.
- The emotional manipulation in blackmail scams is highly personal, while ransomware notes are more formal, structured, and businesslike but both share a common coercive logic.
- Extortion communications overwhelmingly rely on fear, urgency, perceived authority, and isolation to force compliance.
- These common patterns provide a strong foundation for early detection tools, user education, and policy recommendations.

The leveling of all three curves confirms that additional data would yield diminishing returns and that the extracted themes reliably capture the underlying extortion strategies across platforms and scan types. These results demonstrate that despite differences in medium and target, blackmail scams and ransomware operations share a coherent behavioral blueprint, one that is captured and formalized in the Scammer Code Book.

4 Related Work

Research on online fraud, psychological manipulation and ransomware provides a foundation for understanding the behavior of blackmail scammers and the ways victims are targeted. Prior work consistently emphasizes that coercion-based crimes leverage emotion, fear, and digitally amplified anonymity to manipulate victims into compliance.

Early research on cyber-enabled extortion highlights that scammers strategically weaponize fear, shame, and secrecy,

often pressuring victims by threatening the exposure of sensitive information or fabricated wrongdoing. Ahearn's work on blackmail negotiation techniques discusses how blackmailers exploit personal vulnerabilities and rely heavily on emotional leverage rather than the sophisticated technical methods, noting that the "threat of exposure itself is more powerful than the content being exposed" [1]. Similarly, the FBI's public advisory on sextortion stresses that scammers frequently use scripted psychological triggers, including panic, embarrassment, and urgency, to force rapid payment decisions for victims [5].

Recent academic studies further detail how modern scammers exploit human emotional systems. A 2024 SAGE article on digital coercion explains that online extortion schemes rely not only on threats but also on "hyper-personalized manipulation and emotional framing" tailored to the victim's perceived fears [11]. Media analysis also shows scammers designing their messages around emotional vulnerability; for instance, *Time Magazine* reports that scammers deliberately build narratives that heighten stress responses, pushing victims into compliance before rational analysis can occur [4].

Work examining how scammers obtain victim information also informs the understanding of blackmail scams. Incogni's investigative report describes how threat actors compile personal details from data leaks, breached databases, and open-source intelligence (OSINT) to craft messages that appear more credible and targeted [7]. This aligns with findings from cybersecurity experts who note that personalization (real or fabricated) is critical to sustaining believability in blackmail attacks.

Parallel research in generalized online fraud and scam behavior provides additional insight. Verywell Mind's behavioral study of common scams describes emotional manipulation as the central operating mechanism behind most fraud categories, noting that scammers "engineer states of panic, trust, or fear" to reduce victim skepticism [12]. CBS News also highlights how blackmail emails often appear formulaic and mass-distributed, but the psychological impact remains potent because of the universal fear of exposure [2]. Ransomware literature provides an important comparative lens. Unlike classic blackmail messages, ransomware notes act as both threat and a negotiation framework. Academic surveys of ransomware operations show that these notes often follow a recognizable structure: technical instructions, threat escalation, payment deadlines, proof-of-compromise statements, and "customer service"-style communication [8], [9]. These patterns mirror elements found in personal blackmail scams, especially fear-based escalation and strict time limits, but ransomware tends to focus on organizational victims and financial extortion rather than emotional leverage.

Several public data repositories, such as ransomware.live, have enabled large-scale analysis of ransom notes, revealing consistently linguistic markers, intimidation strategies, and psychological framing designed to influence victim behavior.

ior [10]. Comparing these patterns with the emotional and narrative-driven tactics of personal blackmail scams helps situate the present research within a broader ecosystem of online coercion.

Overall, existing literature shows that scammers consistently rely on psychological exploitation, narrative manipulation, and carefully crafted threat structures. However, while extensive research exists for ransomware and general fraud, blackmail scamming, particularly emotionally driven blackmail, remains underexplored academically. The present study contributes to this underdeveloped area by analyzing real blackmail message patterns directly from victim-reported datasets and constructing a cross-scam comparison through the proposed Scammer Code Book.

5 Discussion

The findings of this study reveal that blackmail scammers across email and social media based sextortion, social engineering extortion, and ransomware operations rely heavily on emotional and psychological leverage rather than technical sophistication alone. Patterns identified across ChainAbuse reports, Reddit testimonies, and ransomware note datasets show that the success of blackmail hinges on fear, urgency, and the victim's perceived loss of control. This aligns with the FBI's assessment that blackmail and sextortion exploit "panic-driven compliance" and social vulnerability rather than purely financial incentives [5]. The thematic codes developed in the Scammer Code Book (e.g. threat escalation, social exposure fear, payment urgency, identity claim, authority impersonation) provide further evidence that emotional manipulation is a central mechanism driving these attacks.

One of the most notable insights is the consistency of psychological tactics regardless of platform. Whether a scammer contacts a victim through email, social media, anonymous websites, or ransomware breach notes, the messaging often follows a similar progressions: establish surveillance, claim knowledge of secrets, intensify stakes, and present a single escape option...payment. This mirrors existing research on cyber-enabled coercion, which emphasizes that scammers strategically weaponize emotional triggers to produce compliance [11]. Ransomware notes further reinforce this pattern by threatening data leakage, business downtime, or reputational damage, thus demonstrating how blackmail principles manifest at a larger organizational scale.

Our data sources also highlight an inherent asymmetry: scammers rely on anonymity, automation, and low-effort message templates, while victims face emotional burden, shame, and uncertainty. The scarcity of public reporting (documented previously by the FTC and the FBI) was evident in our dataset. Despite the prevalence of blackmail scams, the volume of public disclosures remains disproportionately small, likely due to embarrassment, fear of exposure, or belief that reporting will not lead to meaningful outcomes. This cultural, psychological,

and social barrier to reporting suggests that official numbers underrepresent the true scale of blackmail-related crimes.

Furthermore, ransomware data collection revealed additional patterns relevant to blackmail motivations. Ransomware operations frequently frame themselves as "professional negotiators", "security testers", or "ethical hackers", which supports prior studies indicating that threat actors rationalize their actions through self-justifying narratives [4]. This provides insight into the psychological worldview of scammers. Many see their work not as theft, but as a transactional service backed by intimidation. Integrating these findings with public victim reports suggests that examining the mindset of scammers, rather than focusing solely on attack vectors, can help improve intervention strategies, user education, and law-enforcement response models.

Despite these contributions, several limitations remain. First, the reliance on publicly shared victim testimonies introduces bias, as individuals willing to publicly disclose scams may represent a specific subset of victims. Second, while scraping ransomware notes provides structural insights, these notes reflect only the communication output of threat actors, not internal motivations, group dynamics, or operational workflows. Third, the anonymity of online platforms prevents validation of demographic patterns; thus, assumptions about ideal target profiles must be interpreted cautiously. Additionally, because many scam cases go unreported, the patterns observed in this study likely represent a partial view of the problem domain.

Overall, this research provides an initial framework for analyzing blackmail scams from both the victim and scammer perspectives. By combining psychological pattern analysis, threat-actor messaging structures, and cross-platform reporting trends, the study contributes toward improving early-warning indicators, awareness education, and forensic understanding of blackmail operations. The next step is to evaluate how the Scammer Code Book can be deployed in real-world scenarios, such as classifier models, user-education modules, or dataset-driven threat-intelligence dashboards, to proactively identify blackmail attempts before victims are harmed.

6 Conclusion

This study set out to examine the structure, behaviors, and recurring patterns found in cryptocurrency-related scams, with a particular focus on ransomware incidents and user-submitted fraud reports from trusted sources such as the FTC, FBI IC3, ChainAbuse, and Reddit's r/scams community. By designing and implementing a modular analysis pipeline, encompassing data collection, cleaning, categorization, and exploratory analysis, we are able to transform large volumes of unstructured online reports into a structured dataset suitable for systematic investigation.

Our findings highlight the consistency and predictability underlying many scam behaviors. Across all data sources,

several categories emerged as dominant, including impersonation scams, investment fraud, giveaway scams, phishing and ransomware extortion. These categories showed clear linguistic and behavioral patterns, including repeated demands for cryptocurrency payment, appeals to urgency or authority, and the reuse of identical or near-identical messages. The ransomware dataset in particular revealed repeated structural language across ransom notes, including payment instructions, threats of data publication, and assurances of "technical support", illustrating how ransomware groups operationalize extortion as a standardized business model.

The analytical pipeline proved effective at surfacing trends that might otherwise remain hidden across fragmented online platforms. Temporal analyses pointed to periods of heightened scam activity, while keyword frequency and content-pattern analysis revealed common rhetorical structures within and across scam categories. These insights reinforce the importance of computational methods for monitoring emergent threats and understanding the evolving nature of online fraud.

Although the system developed for this project focuses on descriptive and pattern-oriented analysis, it establishes the groundwork for future extensions. With additional labeled data, the framework could be expanded to include automated classification, anomaly detection, or real-time risk scoring. Further integration with live reporting platforms could also support early-warning capabilities for emerging fraud campaigns.

In summary, this project demonstrates that structured data processing and pattern-focused analysis can meaningfully enhance our understanding of cryptocurrency scams and ransomware operations. As online fraud continues to increase in scale and sophistication, such data-driven approaches will be essential for researchers, investigators, and policymakers seeking to develop targeted countermeasures and improve public awareness.

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Notes